Somebody Said "Medicaid": Where to Start When Mom Already Needs Care

Three things to write down first, and what to leave for a professional.

Mom needs care now, and your family is paying for it. Somewhere along the way somebody said "Medicaid," somebody else said she has too much money, and nobody explained what either one means for her.

Start here. Three things to write down, in this order.

1 Write down Mom's care and where she is

Note where Mom is being cared for and since when, the state she lives in, the help she gets each day, and who is paying the bill right now. Medicare doesn't pay for long-term care, which is why the Medicaid question comes up, and Medicaid's eligibility rules vary from state to state. [1] [2]

WHY THIS COMES FIRST Mom's care and her state come into every later question, so it helps to have both on paper before the money.

2 List what comes in and what she owns, as far as you know it

Make two short lists: what Mom receives each month and from whom, and what she owns, with whose name is on each. Beside every line write "seen on paper" or "from memory." Don't add anything up. A state measures a person's income and assets against the levels it uses, and those levels are its own. [2]

WHY THIS COMES FIRST "Too much money" is a conclusion. What a professional needs from you is the list it was drawn from.

3 Note what has changed hands, and what you can't find

Write down any gift, any money or property that went to someone else, and any name added to an account or a deed, with rough dates. Then list the papers you looked for and didn't find. When someone applies, a state asks for documentation, may ask what happened to assets, and will want to know whether any were given away. [3]

WHY THIS COMES FIRST You aren't judging any of it. You're making sure the person who reviews Mom's situation sees all of it.

What to leave for a professional

- Whether Mom qualifies, and whether she has "too much."
- Which of the things she owns count, and which don't.
- What "spend down" would mean for her. Until someone who knows her state has explained it, it's a phrase you were told, not an instruction.
- Whether anything on your third list matters.
- Any decision to spend, sell, move or give away something of hers.
- When to apply.

Who the pages go to

Your Medicaid planner reviews what your family has gathered against the Medicaid rules that apply in Mom's state and care setting. Legal questions go to an elder law attorney. If a bill or a notice arrives that you can't make sense of, don't guess at it. Ask the facility's business office, or whoever sent it, what it is.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't interpret a notice, a bill or a rule, say whether Mom qualifies, or tell you what to do with her money, and it isn't legal, financial or tax advice. It puts the first things to write down in order.

Ready for the next step?

You've written down Mom's care, what you know about her income and what she owns, and what has changed hands. The planning interview takes it from there: it asks about your family's situation one question at a time and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care.

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WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The statements about Medicare, about each state using its own rules and levels, and about what a state may ask when someone applies come from the sources below. The three things to write down, and their order, are ours.

1. Medicare.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), Long Term Care Coverage
2. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare information), Medicaid
3. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare information), Applying for Medicaid

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